

and more than once she nearly loses a comrade, but in the end they are triumphant. The Lost Castle of Galistrad is not Arcadia, but even a pale echo of that realm's shining beauty is well worth the price paid to reclaim it.

- ⑤ Nikolai first heard of the Sword of Six Steps during his Saining — it was a story told time and again in the Freehold he found himself in after his Chrysalis, of the magnificent sword that could carry the wielder anywhere, lost centuries ago in the Dreaming. As the years went by, Banality slowly gained a foothold on Nikolai's soul, but the sword never truly left his thoughts. One day, as he told the tale to a fresh young childling, he decided to add an extra line to the story: "And I'm going to find it!" And find it he did, after a long journey in the Dreaming in which he sold his hair to a balding ogre for the knife at its side, which he used to hew down a mighty oak upon which rested the nest of a ferocious roc, from which he saved one egg that hatched into a splendid young bird large enough for him to ride upon. He freed the fledgling when he found the sword and pulled it from the cliff it had been wedged into centuries before. *No need to keep a fellow free spirit chained*, he thought, as the reflection in his blade showed him his dearest friends, and their friends, and theirs in turn and so forth six times over. Who to show off his new treasure to first?
- ⑤ It was supposed to be easy. Virgilius had only been told of the Oaken Clock and its golden pendulum, and not the brambles, briars, and beasts that stood between him and his quarry. For a time, he'd persevered — he could feel the thing calling him in his soul, after all, and such a call is not easily ignored. But when comrades fell, when hunger rose, and when hope slipped away, there was nothing he could do but simply let go. The burden of the quest was too great, even for the promise of freeing his soul from the terrible grip of Banality, from the ever-encroaching Mists that cloud his mind and vision. He is no longer certain if he is awake or dreaming. He is no longer certain of his own name. All he knows, deep in his heart, is that he has failed, but even the knowledge of what he failed to do has slipped through his fingers.

Quest of Inspiration

The second kind of quest undertaken is the Quest of Inspiration, in which a single mortal is chosen as the object. Through whatever means are necessary, the changeling must drive that mortal to the very heights of her creativity, suffusing her with such Glamour that she shines like a beacon in the night. This is not Rhapsody, though — far from it! The changeling must carefully shepherd her charge, ensuring that the maddened drive she has infused the mortal with does not destroy her mind, or the quest will fail. Instead, she must ensure that her chosen mortal's mantle of Glamour sets off a chain of events that, in turn, brings other mortals to the very brink...but not over it. The idea is to create such a wellspring of Glamour that it becomes contagious, without making it so powerful that it becomes lethal.

System: A changeling who hopes to spread the influence of the Dreaming among mortals must first find a mortal or mortals in a position to influence others. Ultimately the scale is not important — the CEO of a marketing firm with creative control is just as valid a target as a well-known bartender or a stand-up comedian. All that matters is that they have frequent contact with a given group of individuals, and are in a position to inspire them in some way. Choosing to follow this quest is an act of volition. Once the changeling finds her subject, she must dedicate herself to inspiring that mortal with a Willpower roll (difficulty of the subject's Banality — for the purposes of this quest, Banality 6 at minimum). If successful, she binds herself to the subject, promising to make her life a little more imaginative and bright. After this, the player must roll Perception + Kenning (difficulty 8) to determine how long the inspiration will take — see *Musing* (p. 261) for details. If the mortal's situation and skills lend themselves to the changeling's *Musing* Threshold, halve the time required. To inspire the mortal, the changeling's player must roll Manipulation + Empathy (difficulty 6) as though she were *Musing* normally, but unless she leaves that Glamour alone, she cannot progress in her quest. For every unit of time, the character may make a single roll — the goal, ultimately, is to accrue more temporary Glamour than the subject's Banality rating, at which point it bleeds into the environment through her works and inspires others. Each point of Glamour thus bled off represents a single mortal inspired — to remove a dot of Banality, a number of mortals equal to the changeling's Banality must be inspired.

- ⑤ Henrietta is a single mother, working two jobs to support her two kids and having scarcely a moment for herself, much less the novel she's been trying to write for five years. Her estranged sister Anastasia, meanwhile, bears the soul of a sidhe duchess, and while the two have not spoken in years Anastasia still feels a connection to her sister. She watches over Henrietta from a distance, and remembers being young, before her Chrysalis, when Henrietta was full of wondrous stories of magic and adventure. It is simple enough to reinsert herself into Henrietta's life, the prodigal sister returning home, all the better to guide Fortune to favor her a little better and help out around the home, watching the children and giving Henrietta the chance to finally sit down and write. She finishes her novel, and its popularity spreads like wildfire — before long, the Internet is teeming with art, fiction, fan series and more, all about the stories that Henrietta used to tell her little sister. The surge of Glamour makes Anastasia feel young again, to say nothing of what it does for Henrietta.
- ⑤ Such is Tabitha's wit and charisma that she is able to hide Banality's slow but steady infiltration of her soul beneath happy tales and a smile that lights up an entire room. One would think inspiration comes easy to her, but she is estranged from mortalkind by the dissonance of her Eshu and human halves, though she moves Heaven and Earth to conceal the most obvious giveaways — shoulders too broad, chin too wide, a laugh a little too deep and loud, and so on. When Tabitha seeks to spurn Banality in a way worthy of a